

WINSOME LOT PM Modi, CM Nitish, LJP(RV) chief Chirag Paswan and RLM chief Upendra Kushwaha at a rally in Samastipur, Oct. 24

ANI

and a central rallying point to boost female voter turnout. Instead of a dole, the NDA narrative also framed the transfer as empowerment for starting small businesses, which possibly did wonders for the self-esteem of the ladies. The special Chhath puja trains to Bihar may also have helped the BJP as party morchas had been active among the Purvanchali communities in various states.

Visual symbolism was another big constant. When the BJP team issued instructions against sloganeering or 'gutka-chewing processions', it was the Sangh cadre who enforced the code. The campaign's tone—orderly, polite, restrained—was deliberate, a sharp contrast to the RJD's raucous rallies. It was the same with the dawn and dusk motorcycle rallies that wound through villages carrying alliance flags. Often the colours were not saffron but those of smaller allies—the LJP, Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular) or RLM. Recognition mattered more than authorship; the goal was to imprint a symbol in the voter's mind. When the little-known RLM candidate Madhav Anand won in Madhubani, polling nearly 98,000 votes under the 'gas cylinder' symbol, BJP managers called it proof that the "shared symbol" strategy had worked. Indeed, the smaller allies won 28 of the 41 seats allocated to them.

The orderly, polite and restrained tone of the NDA campaign was deliberate, to bring out the sharp contrast with the raucous RJD rallies

The 2024 Lok Sabha setback had exposed the weaknesses in the BJP's middle-rung leadership. District presidents complained that booth workers had drifted away to do odd jobs. To rebuild, the RSS revived the *sampark abhiyaans*—a door-to-door outreach. By early 2025, over 4,000 daily shakhas were functioning again, compared to 2,800 a year earlier. This surge coincided with a spurt in small-scale welfare events: helping with housing paperwork, facilitating PM-Kisan registrations, eye check-up camps. For many villagers, the 'social worker' v=became synonymous with the 'RSS volunteer'. That invisible groundwork and their feedback gave the data in Shah's nightly reviews credibility. So, when reports came in from Seemanchal about fence-sitting minority voters, or from Rohtas about surplus youth volunteers, he knew they were genuine. "It was Sangh intelligence that filled the gaps in our data sheets," says a BJP campaign manager.